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Fulfillment Decision Toolkit

Choosing how to fulfill orders is one of your first big decisions as an online seller. This toolkit simplifies the 3pl vs dropshipping vs self fulfillment choice with clear checklists...



7 pages · PDF

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Choosing how to fulfill orders is one of your first big decisions as an online seller. This toolkit simplifies the 3pl vs dropshipping vs self fulfillment choice with clear checklists and straightforward guidance.

01 Quick Start: Which Method Fits You?

Before diving into detailed comparisons, answer these three questions:

1. **How much money can you invest upfront?** (Under $500, $500–$2000, or $2000+)
2. **How many hours weekly can you dedicate?** (5 hours, 10–20 hours, or 20+ hours)
3. **What's your 6-month goal?** (Test ideas, steady side income, or full-time business)

Your answers point you in the right direction, but let's break down each option properly.

02 Self Fulfillment Checklist

Start with self fulfillment if you check 3+ boxes:

- [ ] You have less than $1,000 to start
- [ ] You're selling under 50 orders monthly
- [ ] You have storage space at home
- [ ] You want complete control over packaging
- [ ] You're selling handmade or customized products
- [ ] You have 10+ hours weekly for packing and shipping
- [ ] You live near a post office or shipping center
- [ ] You want to learn operations hands-on

What you'll need to start:

- Shipping scale ($20–40)
- Packaging supplies (boxes, tape, labels)
- Shipping software or platform account
- Storage shelving or bins
- Printer for shipping labels

Cost reality: Expect $100–300 for initial supplies, then $5–15 per order for packaging and shipping.

03 Dropshipping Checklist

Consider dropshipping if you check 3+ boxes:

- [ ] You have under $500 startup capital
- [ ] You want to test multiple products quickly
- [ ] You don't have storage space
- [ ] You're comfortable with 20–40% profit margins
- [ ] You can handle 3–4 week shipping times
- [ ] You want minimal physical work
- [ ] You're patient with supplier communication
- [ ] You're tech-savvy enough to use supplier platforms

What you'll need to start:

- Online store platform subscription
- Supplier account (AliExpress, Spocket, etc.)
- Product research tools
- Basic marketing budget ($100–500)
- Customer service system

Cost reality: Expect $50–200 monthly for tools and platforms. Products cost nothing until they sell, but profit margins are lower.

04 3PL Checklist

Evaluate 3pl vs dropshipping or self fulfillment with 3PL if you check 3+ boxes:

- [ ] You're shipping 100+ orders monthly
- [ ] You have $3,000+ for initial inventory
- [ ] You want to focus on growth, not operations
- [ ] You need 2–3 day shipping speeds
- [ ] Your products have good profit margins (40%+)
- [ ] You're ready to commit to bulk inventory
- [ ] You want professional warehousing

- [ ] You plan to scale quickly

What you'll need to start:

- Vetted 3PL provider with good reviews
- Initial inventory purchase
- Integration between store and 3PL
- Inventory management software
- Cash flow for ongoing fees

Cost reality: Expect $200–800 monthly in storage and fulfillment fees, plus inventory costs. Volume makes this more affordable per unit.

05 Your Decision Framework

Use this self fulfillment checklist to evaluate your situation:

Budget Assessment

- Under $500 = Dropshipping or self fulfillment
- $500–$2,000 = Self fulfillment with inventory
- $2,000–$5,000 = Self fulfillment or small 3PL
- $5,000+ = 3PL becomes viable

Time Assessment

- Under 5 hours weekly = Dropshipping or 3PL
- 10–20 hours weekly = Any method works
- 20+ hours weekly = Self fulfillment to learn, then scale

Volume Assessment

- 0–30 orders/month = Self fulfillment
- 30–100 orders/month = Self fulfillment or dropshipping
- 100–500 orders/month = Consider 3PL
- 500+ orders/month = Definitely 3PL

06 Making Your Choice: Action Steps

Step 1: Complete all three checklists above honestly.

Step 2: Calculate your true costs. Don't forget to value your time—if packing boxes takes 3 hours and you value your time at $20/hour, that's $60 in real cost.

Step 3: Start with the method that checks the most boxes. You're not locked in forever.

Step 4: Set a review date (3 months out) to evaluate if your fulfillment method still makes sense.

Step 5: Document everything you do. When you're ready to switch methods, you'll need these processes.

07 Common Mistakes to Avoid

When comparing 3pl vs dropshipping or self fulfillment, beginners often:

- **Underestimate time costs** with self fulfillment (packing takes longer than you think)
- **Overestimate 3PL affordability** at low volumes (fees eat profits quickly)
- **Choose dropshipping without vetting suppliers** (leading to customer complaints)
- **Switch methods too quickly** (give each approach at least 60 days)

08 Your Next Move

You now have a practical self fulfillment checklist and framework for comparing all three options. Pick the method that checked the most boxes for your situation, gather the supplies you need, and launch.

Remember: Most successful sellers start with one method and evolve. Your first choice teaches you about operations and customers, setting you up to scale smarter later.

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